

You can download the last stable release of GNU Emacs *emacs-24.5.tar.gz* from <http://ftp.gnu.org/gnu/emacs> and then unpack it to your home directory. Before installing Emacs, it's necessary to install the following software:

```
sudo apt-get install gtklp cups-pdf build-essential libx11-
dev xaw3d-dev libjpeg-dev libpng12-dev libgif-dev libtiff4-
dev libncurses5-dev libxft-dev libsvg2-dev libmagickcore-
dev libmagick++-dev libxml2-dev libgpm-dev libghc-gconf-dev
libotf-dev libm17n-dev libgnutls-dev
```

The Emacs installation process involves the following steps from the terminal window:

```
cd /home/[your-username]/emacs-24.5
./configure
make
sudo make install
```

The two programs, *gtklp* and *cups-pdf*, are very useful to simplify the printing from Emacs by adding the following two lines in your dotemacs file */home/[your-username]/.emacs*:

```
(setq lpr-command "gtklp"
      ps-lpr-command "gtklp")
```

This way, the printing process is managed by a GTK GUI in which you can print to a PDF file or to a printer. One more thing about the colour themes — as an alternative to the adoption of a specific colour theme, I prefer to change only some colours by adding the following code to the dotemacs file:

```
(custom-set-faces
 '(font-lock-keyword-face ((t (:foreground
"#0000CD")))) ;; Medium blue
 '(font-lock-type-face ((t (:foreground
"#DC143C")))) ;; Crimson
 '(font-lock-constant-face ((t (:foreground
"#FF8C00")))) ;; Dark orange
 '(font-lock-builtin-face ((t (:foreground
"#1E90FF")))) ;; Dodger blue
 '(font-lock-function-name-face ((t (:foreground
"#800080")))) ;; Purple
 '(font-lock-string-face ((t (:foreground
"#808080")))) ;; Gray
 '(font-lock-comment-face ((t (:foreground
"#3CB371")))) ;; Medium sea green
```

About Vim, the directory for the colour themes is */usr/share/vim/vim74/colors* and for the syntax-highlighting files is */usr/share/vim/vim74/syntax*. So, if you have some of them, you must copy your files to these directories. If you want to recognise the *lstlisting* environment as in Vim 7.3, you can use the following code in */usr/share/vim/vim74/syntax/textlstlisting.vim*:

```
let b:loaded_lstlisting="vib"
syn region texZone start="\begin[lstlisting]" end="\end[lstlisting]"\|>
syn region texZone start="\lstinputlisting" end="{\s*[a-Z/-0-9_^\]\s*}"
```

Because the default configuration file is almost empty, edit *gvimrc* with *sudo gedit* (or *gvim*) */etc/vim/gvimrc* and paste it as a basic configuration, for example, as in the following lines:

```
set cryptmethod=blowfish
set encoding=utf-8 " The encoding displayed
set fileencoding=utf-8 " The encoding written to file
set foldmethod=marker
set guifont=Inconsolata\ Medium\ 11
set guioptions-=T
set number
set textwidth=80
set wrapmargin=0
source $VIMRUNTIME/mswin.vim
bheave mswin
```

The last two lines are useful to make the cut, copy and paste commands work as in Windows with *Ctrl+X*, *Ctrl+C* and *Ctrl+V* (see Reference 7).

Installation and configuration of Linux is not as difficult as is sometimes reported. It is possible for GNU Linux to be the only system installed on your computer along with a wide range of great programs. Almost 20 years have passed since the article cited in the introduction was published, and during this time, developers have taken great steps forward. For the future, I hope that LibreOffice will continue to have its present GUI. I also hope that Xfce will have more customisation options. 

References

- [1] Gonzato, Il free software al lavoro (The free software at work), Byte (Italian edition), 1998, 8, 96-99.
- [2] http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Media_Transfer_Protocol, last visited on 26/02/2016.
- [3] <http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Zenity>, last visited on 26/02/2016.
- [4] <http://help.gnome.org/users/zenity/stable>, last visited on 26/02/2016.
- [5] <http://www.alldovarotto.org/computer/linux/fax.htm>, last visited on 26/02/2016.
- [6] Arnote, Just the fax Ma'am... and it works in Linux!, PCLinuxOS Magazine, 2013, 72, 38-47.
- [7] <http://superuser.com/questions/10588>, last visited on 26/02/2016.

By: Stefano Rizzi

The author works in the analytical chemistry and textile chemistry areas. He has been a Linux user since 1998.